IELTS PREPARATION GUIDE

From Band 6.5 to 8.0: A Complete Walkthrough

The most effective way to understand IELTS Writing is to take a standard Task 2 answer, evaluate it across the four core criteria, and systematically elevate it to a Band 8.0 standard.

EXAMPLE IELTS TASK 2 QUESTION

Some people believe that university education should be free for everyone. Others believe students should pay for their education. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Baseline Answer (~Band 6.5)

Read the typical response below. It is decent, but lacks the depth and precision required for top-tier bands.

> *University education is becoming increasingly important in modern society. Some people think that it should be free for everyone, while others believe that students should pay for it. This essay will discuss both views and explain why I believe university education should be affordable, but not necessarily completely free.*
>
> *On the one hand, free university education can provide equal opportunities for students from different backgrounds. Poor students may have the ability to succeed academically but cannot afford expensive tuition fees. If education is free, these students can attend university and develop their skills. This can also benefit society because more educated people can contribute to the economy.*
>
> *On the other hand, making university education completely free can be expensive for governments. Universities require money to pay teachers, maintain buildings and provide modern equipment. If the government pays for everything, it may need to increase taxes or reduce spending in other important areas. Furthermore, some students who can afford university may receive the same financial support as students from poor families.*
>
> *In my opinion, university education should be affordable rather than completely free. Governments should provide scholarships and financial assistance to students who genuinely cannot afford tuition fees. At the same time, students who can afford to contribute should pay a reasonable amount. This would make higher education more accessible without putting excessive financial pressure on governments.*

How would this be scored?

IELTS examiners do not give one overall impression first. They assess the four criteria separately.

Criterion	Approx. Score	Why
TA (Task Achievement)	7	Answers both views and gives a clear opinion.
CC (Coherence & Cohesion)	7	Clear 4-paragraph structure and logical progression.
LR (Lexical Resource)	6–7	Good vocabulary, but not particularly sophisticated.
GRA (Grammatical Range)	6–7	Generally accurate, but sentence structures could be more varied.

1. Task Achievement (TA)

The essay currently does a good job of directly addressing the prompt: it covers View 1 (equal opportunities), View 2 (government costs/fairness), and provides a clear Opinion (affordable, not free). However, to reach Band 8, you cannot just mention an idea; you must **develop it**.

WEAK (BAND 6)

Free education helps poor students.

BETTER (BAND 8)

Removing tuition fees could widen access to higher education, particularly for capable students from low-income households who might abandon university due to constraints.

The TA Trick: Development Chain

For every main idea, map it out: **POINT → WHY → RESULT → EXAMPLE**

- **Point:** Free education helps poor students.
- **Why:** Because tuition fees are expensive.
- **Result:** Therefore, more capable students can attend university.
- **Example:** For example, students from low-income families could pursue degrees without taking on substantial debt.

2. Coherence & Cohesion (CC)

Coherence and Cohesion asks: *"Can the examiner easily follow my argument?"* A common mistake is assuming that adding more mechanical linking words (Firstly, moreover, furthermore, however, therefore) equals a higher CC score. This actually sounds unnatural.

MECHANICAL LINKING (BAND 6)

Firstly, free education provides opportunities for poor students. Moreover, it helps society. Furthermore, it can improve the economy.

LOGICAL COHESION (BAND 8)

Free education can provide opportunities for students from disadvantaged backgrounds. As a result, more academically capable students may attend university and eventually contribute to the economy.

The CC Trick: Blueprinting

Before writing, make a tiny paragraph-level structure. Every paragraph should have exactly one central purpose.

Intro ↓ BP1: Why free? ↓ BP2: Why pay? ↓ Opinion/Solution

3. Lexical Resource (LR)

There is an important misconception that Band 8 requires extremely difficult or obscure words. In reality, Band 8 rewards **appropriate, precise, and varied vocabulary**. Instead of memorizing random fancy synonyms, focus on academic phrasing.

Basic English (~Band 6)	Precise Academic Phrasing (~Band 8)
poor people / students	low-income households / disadvantaged backgrounds
rich people	affluent households
pay for university	finance higher education
university education	higher education / tertiary education
government money	public funding
help students	provide financial assistance
very expensive	financially burdensome / substantial tuition fees
get a degree / get a job	obtain a degree / secure employment

The LR Trick: Collocations over Synonyms

Build collocation groups instead of single words. For the topic of Education, learn chunks like: *pursue higher education, academic performance, educational opportunities,* and *higher-education institutions.*

4. Grammatical Range & Accuracy (GRA)

GRA requires controlled variety. You do not need to deliberately make every sentence endlessly complicated. A high-scoring essay weaves simple, compound, and complex sentences together naturally, with near-perfect accuracy.

- **Complex:** Governments should provide financial assistance to students who cannot afford tuition fees.
- **Conditional:** If governments provided greater financial assistance, more disadvantaged students could access higher education.
- **Passive:** Tuition fees are often regarded as a major barrier to university education.

> **The Biggest Band 8 Secret:** Stop thinking, *"How can I make my essay sound complicated?"* Start thinking, *"How can I express a clear idea precisely and naturally?"* That is exactly what IELTS rewards.

Putting It Together: A Band 8 Transformation

Here is how we integrate TA, CC, LR, and GRA to completely upgrade a single body paragraph from the original essay.

ORIGINAL (~BAND 6.5)

> *On the one hand, free university education can provide equal opportunities for students from different backgrounds. Poor students may have the ability to succeed academically but cannot afford expensive tuition fees. If education is free, these students can attend university and develop their skills. This can also benefit society because more educated people can contribute to the economy.*

IMPROVED (BAND 8+)

> *On the one hand, publicly funded higher education could widen access to university, particularly for academically capable students from low-income households. For many such students, substantial tuition fees represent a significant barrier to obtaining a degree, regardless of their academic potential. Removing this financial obstacle could therefore enable a broader section of society to acquire advanced skills and qualifications, which may ultimately contribute to higher productivity and economic growth.*

Pre-Submission Checklist

Before concluding your writing practice, review your essay against these exact parameters:

TA & CC Focus

- Did I answer every part of the question?
- Is my position/opinion completely clear?
- Did I explain my main ideas using the chain method?
- Does every paragraph have a clear purpose?
- Do my ideas logically connect without relying heavily on "Firstly, Moreover"?

LR & GRA Focus

- Are my word choices precise and academic?
- Am I using natural word collocations?
- Did I vary my sentence structures seamlessly?
- Did I check articles (a/an/the) and subject-verb agreement?
- Did I verify spelling and plural nouns?

The Target Mindset

Do not obsess over memorizing "Band 8 vocabulary lists." Your logical argument, depth of development, grammatical accuracy, and natural word choice matter far more than forcing difficult words into your essay. **Clarity is king.**